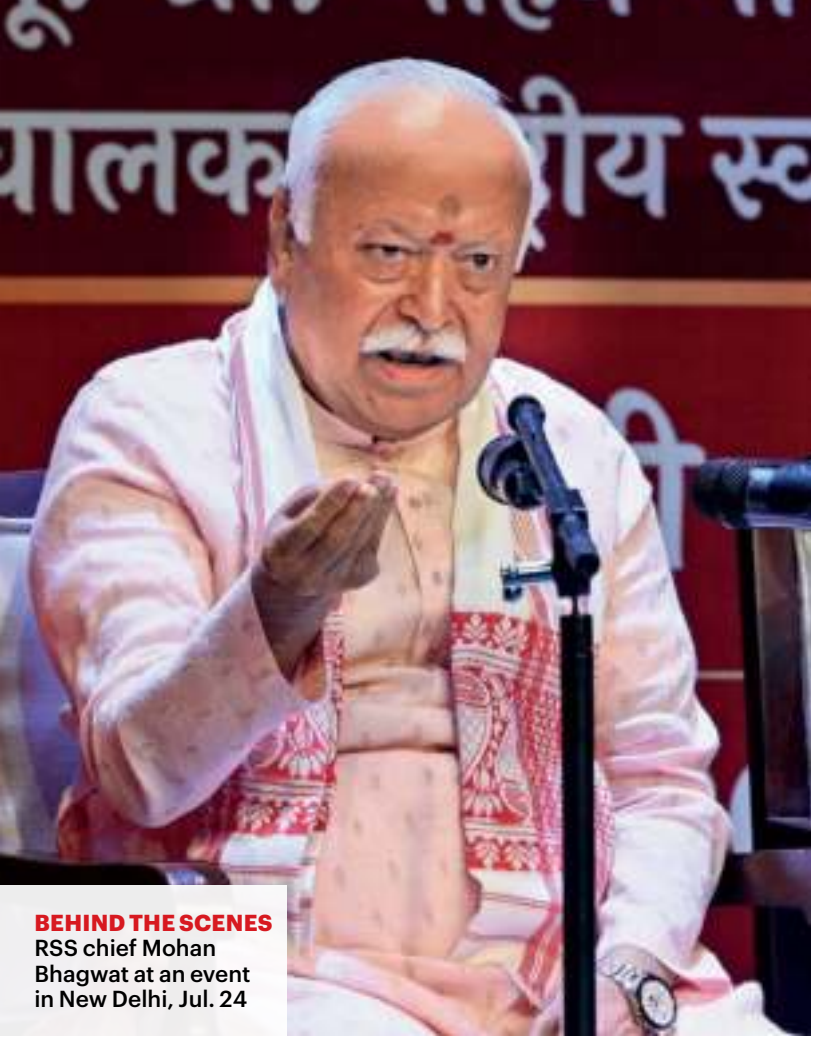


BEHIND THE SCENES
RSS chief Mohan Bhagwat at an event in New Delhi, Jul. 24

ARUN KUMAR

RSS IS SAID TO BE UNHAPPY WITH THE USE OF FORCE ON THE PROTESTERS. CHIEF BHAGWAT AT AN EVENT SAID GEN Z NEEDED TO BE HEARD, NOT REPRIMANDED

Which means that to retain UP in March 2027, Modi cannot merely hold on to his base; he has to expand it—a formidable challenge that will require reclaiming the narrative, rejuvenating the BJP cadre and Sangh volunteers on the ground and curbing factionalism.

5. KEEPING THE RSS HAPPY

What should also worry Modi and the BJP is the conspicuous silence of the wider Sangh Parivar during the entire Gen Z agitation. In earlier battles, the affiliates of the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS) could be counted on to build a counter-narrative, mobilise support or put their own numbers on the streets. This time, there was little sign of any such intervention. The conclusion many BJP workers have drawn is that the government was left to take the beating on its own.

The silence, though, was not absolute. On July 24, a day before Pradhan's resignation, RSS sarsanghchalak Mohan Bhagwat, while addressing the closing session of the Vishwa Mangalya Sabha's national meeting on contemporary motherhood at Delhi's Ambedkar International Centre, said his generation had grown up in a culture of obedience, but today's youth were different. They ask questions and have to be given reasons, affection and time. He made no reference to Jantar Mantar, but the message for Modi was unmistakable.

A second version has been doing the rounds since: that the Sangh was not absent so much as unconvinced. According to sources, blunt feedback reached the prime minister after July 20—that the police action had created a rupture with sections of the BJP's core constituency. The RSS is itself in the midst of a major Gen Z outreach initiative as part of its centenary celebration. Watching a government that it helped build deploy tear gas, lathis and pellet guns against students in the national capital was hardly the message that campaign needed.

Either interpretation poses a problem for Modi, say experts. But the second one is more consequential. The Sangh may have partly reconciled with the BJP leadership, put its workers behind the party's machine in crucial states and had a say in a few state units, but it has not bothered to hide its displeasure. For example, it has been sitting quiet for two years on the BJP request to release 14 prachaaraks as general secretaries (organisation) in its state units. That post is the pivot on which a state unit turns, and the incumbent is traditionally the RSS's man inside the party. Eight states still have the vacancy, poll-bound Uttarakhand among them. The BJP leadership understands that they also need the Sangh's workforce and leadership to triumph in Lucknow a third time.

6. RESHUFFLING TEAM MODI

This is the only challenge that is entirely within Modi's control, which is why the delay has begun to beg an explanation. Experts say a meaningful reshuffle of the council of ministers has been overdue for some time. The string of assembly victories after 2024—Haryana, Maharashtra, Delhi and Bihar—was expected to provide the chance to move people out, induct fresh faces and clarify who was accountable for what. It never came. As a result, there are ministers who have been occupying the same portfolios for years without any